



LADWP workers gather the day after the July 16 pipe rupture on Sunset Boulevard in West Hollywood.

GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

Chinese AI is gaining ground in U.S.

The models may not be as powerful as their American rivals, but they are less costly.

BY CHAN HO-HIM AND MATT O'BRIEN

HONG KONG — China has a hot new product in the United States: artificial intelligence.

San Francisco-based Raffi Krikorian, the chief technology officer at Mozilla, which runs the Firefox browser, switched to Chinese AI startup Moonshot's Kimi K3 for many of his day-to-day activities within days of the new, powerful model's launch more than a week ago.

"It just seems snappier," he said of K3, comparing it with the acclaimed and more expensive Claude Fable chatbot from San Francisco company Anthropic. Earlier, he had been using another high-performing Chinese model, Z.ai's GLM-5.2, for routine tasks such as managing his calendar, documents and email.

Krikorian is one of a growing number of Americans adopting Chinese AI systems, which are gaining ground around the world because they are more affordable and increasingly efficient. U.S. companies such as cryptocurrency exchange Coinbase said they're switching to Chinese AI models to help trim costs.

Their popularity has frustrated some U.S. tech giants, but short of an outright ban, they're likely to continue to appeal to independent software developers in the U.S. and elsewhere.

American-led restrictions block China from accessing some of the world's most advanced technologies including cutting-edge AI chips, and U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent has warned more sanctions could be coming to protect

[See AI, A8]

Paramount's Warner deal is appearing less certain

BY MEG JAMES

Tech scion David Ellison for months projected confidence that his blockbuster Hollywood merger was on a glide path to completion.

His media company Paramount Skydance's pitch early this year was that its proposed \$111-billion acquisition of rival Warner Bros. Discovery could easily clear regulatory hurdles — unlike Netflix's competing bid.

Ellison has heavyweights in his corner: His billionaire father, Larry Ellison, co-founder of software giant Oracle, is bankrolling the

deal, and President Trump is eager for the Ellison family to own CNN and other Warner assets, including HBO and the Burbank film and TV studios behind "Batman," Harry Potter, Wile E. Coyote and "The Pitt."

"We could technically close [the deal] tomorrow," Ellison told business news channel CNBC during a March interview. "There is nothing in this transaction that trips anything that would create cause for concern."

But Paramount made a dramatic retreat Friday after two weeks of legal setbacks. The firm had been

aiming to close the deal by September but agreed to table its takeover — perhaps until next spring — to allow a fiercer-than-expected challenge from California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta and 11 other Democratic state attorneys general to advance to trial before an Oakland-based federal judge.

The state prosecutors allege that Paramount's proposed merger with Warner Bros. violates a century-old antitrust law by giving the combined company too much heft in theatrical movie distribution and cable television. Paramount dis-

[See Paramount, A7]



ANNA HOCH-KENNEY CalMatters

MAYA HOTZ checks on Douglas fir seedlings at a Cal Fire nursery in Davis.

Reforesting, too slowly

Fires, fed cuts overwhelm state replanting efforts

BY RACHEL BECKER

A windowless warehouse in Northern California shelters pieces of the state's forests.

Icy air swirls and fogs around 42,000 pounds of seeds — the past and the future of these trees, frozen in cardboard boxes. It smells like the woods on a snowy day.

"This is like the mothership of forestry in California right here," said Stewart Mc-Morrow, staff chief for wildfire resilience at the California Department of Forestry and Fire Protection, standing outside the heavy metal door of the state seed bank at the agency's Lewis A. Moran Reforestation Center on the outskirts of Davis.

Private landowners especially rely on these seeds — some now more than half a century old — to reforest property destroyed by wildfire.

At the pace California is burning, it's nowhere near enough.

Climate change and more than a century of overzealous fire suppression are now fueling wildfires so severe that they're wiping out the very forests that need fire to thrive — leaving celebrated landscapes at risk of turning to brush and scrub, permanently.

Over the last quarter of a century,

[See Replant, A6]

How the L.A. City Council measures up

BY NOAH GOLDBERG

There's no exact way to measure the effectiveness of Los Angeles City Council members.

But we analyzed three basic elements — meeting attendance, committee assignments and amount of legislation drafted — to give readers a sense of what their local electeds are up to.

Meeting attendance

As part of charter reform efforts, the City Council sent a measure to the November ballot asking voters to allow it to reduce the number of council meetings from three per week to just one.

The proposal received stiff pushback from at least one council member, Monica Rodriguez.

"Meeting less for a city of

4 million people I think sends the wrong message. Particularly when you have the best-paid council in the country," said Rodriguez in an interview on Fox 11 earlier this year (each council member makes an annual salary of more than \$244,000). "This idea that we would be meeting less I believe runs contrary to what the public is demanding from their council."

Yet Rodriguez isn't a stickler for showing up to meetings herself, ranking near the bottom among her colleagues for attendance. Since the start of 2025, Rodriguez has attended about 86% of meetings, missing 25 out of 177 meetings, according to a Times analysis.

Gabriel Avalos, a spokesperson for Rodriguez, implied that other work-re-

[See City Council, A7]

L.A.'s perilous game of water pipeline triage

With money scarce, repairs occur only in areas considered most likely to break next.

BY HANNAH FRY

The Los Angeles water system is so old — and money for replacements is exceedingly scarce — that officials are left playing a dangerous game of triage.

They know huge swaths of the system are in desperate need of replacement. But with limited time and money, the Los Angeles Department of Water and Power has no choice but to focus on the lines it believes are most likely to blow.

Sometimes, it can get there before a massive leak. But as West Hollywood discovered this month, sometimes the pipes rupture well before help can arrive.

The Westside has experienced the highest number of leaks across the city's water distribution system over the last 10 years, according to the utility.

Experts say the age of pipes, the corrosive soil they're buried in and pressure changes in pipes that send water to hillside neigh-

borhoods all contribute to breaks across the aging system.

This region was the location of the two biggest ruptures of the last dozen years: a 17-million gallon leak in West Hollywood this month and a roughly 10-million gallon rupture that flooded Westwood and damaged parts of UCLA in 2014.

Those areas both had pipes that were more than 100 years old. But the rest of the system isn't much better.

More than 30% of the DWP's main lines are more than 80 years old and at least 6% of them are considered high priority for replacement. A 2018 assessment said that more than 50% of the DWP's trunk line segments were over 65 years old and 11% were more than 100 years old.

The utility prioritizes replacement projects based on a variety of factors including the age of the line, leak history and the consequences of failure in a particular area. DWP engineers weigh those factors when prioritizing pipes for replacement, assigning a letter grade to each water main based on its likelihood of failure and the potential consequences of a break.

[See Water, A6]

OLD PIPES: Steve Lopez says that a vulnerable network delivers 400 million gallons daily. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Thousands of bias claims, few officers punished

BY LIBOR JANY

Over the last decade, the LAPD has received thousands of complaints accusing officers of targeting people solely because of their race, ethnicity or other form of outward appearance.

Only one has been fired for it.

The former officer, Edgar Garcia Cancino, was part of a San Fernando Valley anti-gang unit whose members were alleged to have improperly pulled over and searched hundreds of motorists. Cancino has appealed his termination, arguing that other officers in his unit carried out more of the problematic stops. He claimed the department sought to make an example of him because he refused to implicate his superiors in wrongdoing.

Accusations of racial profiling have long dogged the department, alienating generations of Black and brown

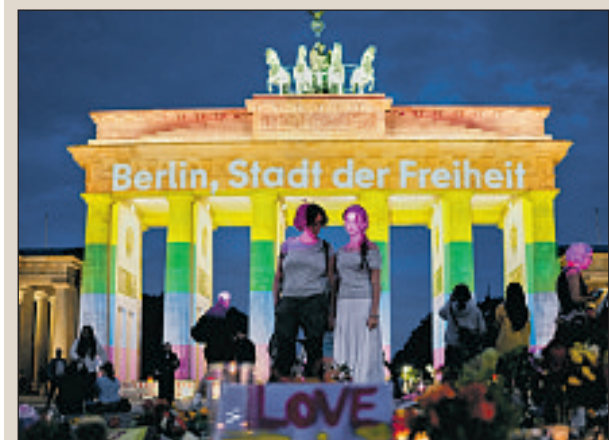
Angelenos. Known within the LAPD as "biased policing," such complaints have persisted despite repeated attempts to enact reform. But the question of how commonly profiling occurs in the Los Angeles Police Department remains a topic of pointed debate.

Years of studies by researchers and reporting by The Times and other news outlets have found that Black and Latino people in L.A. are subjected to stops, frisks, searches and arrests at significantly higher rates than white people, regardless of whether they live in high-crime neighborhoods.

Past LAPD chiefs have acknowledged that isolated cases of profiling may occur. At the same time, they have denied that there is a widespread, systemic problem.

An internal LAPD investigation of Cancino's Mission Division gang squad uncovered an "overwhelming

[See LAPD, A5]



EBRAHIM NOROOZI Associated Press

BERLIN SUSPECT KILLED

Police shoot the man believed to have driven a van into a crowd near a Pride festival. Above, a Brandenburg Gate vigil on Sunday. **WORLD, A2**

Preservationists fighting cleanup

Bid to filter out fecal contamination in Arroyo Seco meets resistance. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Limits to elite film formats

"The Odyssey" in 70mm soars, but let's not get carried away. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather
Mostly sunny; warm.
L.A. Basin: 88/68. **B5**



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